Problem Solving Project:

Improving Training Procedures for GrillMarX Employees

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Introduction

GrillMarx Steakhouse & Raw Bar is a locally owned Maryland restaurant group with three full-service locations, each offering a classic American steakhouse experience augmented by a raw oyster bar. Although menus are largely standardized across sites, slight regional variations accommodate local tastes. At the heart of the College Park, Maryland GrillMarx location operations is a dynamic, primarily student-aged workforce: servers and bartenders average a 2–3-year turnover rate, reflecting that many are college students balancing work with academics.

To onboard its high-turnover staff, GrillMarx employs a five-day, instructor-led training program at each restaurant, structured around both classroom and on-the-job components. On Day 1, during the quieter early shift hours, trainees work one-on-one with a "lead server", (or, for bartenders, a member of the bar team) to review a comprehensive binder that covers food safety protocols, equipment operation, menu details, and upselling strategies. As the kitchen and dining room ramp up, new hires begin shadowing their trainers, observing table turns, order entry, and guest interactions, with live commentary on best practices. Training days vary: some start with an early shift shadow, others extend through a full-service period, and menu-section deep dives (e.g., operational stations, food tastings, beer/wine/liquor workshops) are interspersed throughout. At the end of Day 5, servers participate in a manager-led mock service for formal evaluation, while bartenders move directly into shadow shifts without a written or practical exam. Trainees may take their binder home for further review, but without scheduled e-learning or follow-up quizzes, mastery depends heavily on individual self-motivation.

Despite the uniform curriculum, post-training feedback and managerial observation reveal pronounced variability in on-floor service quality. While some employees deliver impeccable service, accurately following safety procedures, menu recommendations, and upselling protocols — others routinely omit key steps, leading to customer complaints and lost revenue. These trends indicate that GrillMarx's current massed-practice, all-in-person approach, though thorough, fails to produce consistent, durable service behaviors across its workforce. While this can be attributed to multiple shortcomings, such as too much dependency on self-motivation or a lack of multimedia learning, there is current research and organizational understanding of these issues. In the sections that follow, we'll diagnose this issue using three I-O psychology concepts (massed vs. spaced practice, training transfer, and self-efficacy) and propose a blended, multimedia training system designed to support learning before, during, and after the training period.